



THE REPUBLIC OF VANUATU IS MADE UP of 80 islands scattered over the Pacific Ocean in a “Y” shape. Most of the islands are volcanic in origin, while a few are coral islands. There are frequent earth tremors in the area

NI-VANUATU

THE PEOPLE OF THE VOLCANO

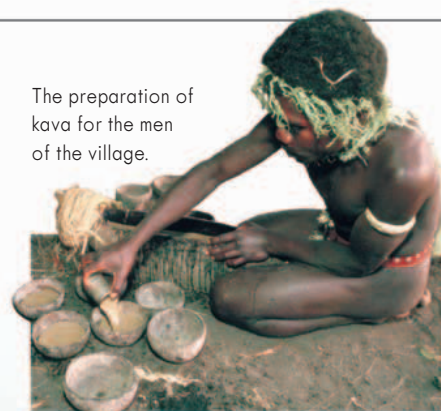
Vanuatu Cultural Center

The people of Vanuatu are fiercely proud of their cultures and many value a traditional way of life. The Vanuatu Cultural Center was started in 1977 and has over 80 volunteers. They travel all over the islands collecting information about local cultures. They then write up literature about them to document and preserve them, and to promote the islands all over the world.



MOUNT YASUR

Tanna Island, part of Vanuatu, is a place where the culture and custom remain strong. The island is volcanic and explosions occur regularly on Mount Yasur. Most local people believe that the volcano is the house of spirits and rituals are held to honor it.



The preparation of kava for the men of the village.

KAVA

All over Vanuatu a favorite drink is kava. At dusk men start gathering and preparing the kava root. They chew it, then spit it into a bowl and add water. They always drink it fresh and, as it is a potent drug, it aids their sleep.



ISLAND MUSIC

The Ni-Vanuatu pride themselves on their musical instruments. This young boy, wearing a loincloth and decorative leaves, holds a long bamboo tube. While he sings, he thrusts the bamboo against a wooden board, creating rhythmic, musical sounds.

THE TOKA DANCE

The most famous dance on Tanna Island is the *toka* dance. The volcano ceremony starts with the women dancing all night, then at sunrise the men from many villages take over.